

Cristiano Ronaldo (born February 5, 1985, [Funchal, Madeira, Portugal](#)) is a Portuguese [football](#) (soccer) forward who is one of the greatest players of his generation. [Ronaldo](#) is the winner of five Ballon d’Or awards (2008, 2013, 2014, 2016, and 2017), and in 2024 he became the first men’s player to score 900 career goals in official matches.

Early life and career

Ronaldo’s father, José Dinis Aveiro, was the equipment manager for the local club Andorinha. (The name Ronaldo was added to Cristiano’s name in honor of his father’s favorite movie actor, [Ronald Reagan](#), who was U.S. president at the time of Cristiano’s birth.) At age 15 Ronaldo was diagnosed with a heart condition that necessitated surgery, but he was sidelined only briefly and made a full recovery. He first played for Clube Desportivo Nacional of Madeira and then transferred to Sporting Clube de Portugal (known as Sporting Lisbon), where he played for that club’s various youth teams before making his debut on Sporting’s first team in 2002.

A tall player at 6 feet 1 inch (1.85 meters), Ronaldo was a [formidable](#) athlete on the pitch. Originally a right-winger, he developed into a forward with a free-reined attacking style. He was able to mesmerize opponents with a sleight of foot that made sufficient space for openings in opposing defenses.

Club play

After a successful season with Sporting that brought the young player to the attention of Europe’s biggest football clubs, Ronaldo signed with English powerhouse [Manchester United](#) in 2003. He was an instant sensation and soon came to be regarded as one of the best forwards in the game. His finest season with United came in 2007–08, when he scored 42 League and Cup goals and earned the Golden Shoe award as Europe’s leading scorer, with 31 League goals. After helping United to a Champions League title in May 2008, Ronaldo captured [Fédération Internationale de Football Association](#) (FIFA) World Player of the Year honors for his stellar 2007–08 season. He also led United to an appearance in the 2009 Champions League final, which they lost to [FC Barcelona](#).



[One of the greatest goal scorers](#) Cristiano Ronaldo (yellow jersey) of Al Nassr in a match against Abha, 2023.

Soon thereafter Ronaldo was sold to [Spain’s Real Madrid](#)—a club with which he had long been rumored to want to play—for a then record £80 million (about \$131 million)

transfer fee. His scoring [prowess](#) continued with his new team, and he netted the most goals (40) in La Liga history during the 2010–11 season (his record was broken the following season by his rival [Lionel Messi](#) of Barcelona). In 2011–12 Ronaldo helped Madrid capture a La Liga championship and scored a personal-best 46 goals during the League season. He scored a total of 66 goals in 56 appearances with Madrid and the Portuguese national team in 2013 to earn his second world player of the year award (the FIFA World Player of the Year was renamed the FIFA Ballon d'Or in 2010).

In 2014 he scored 52 goals in 43 games and led Madrid to a Champions League title, which resulted in Ronaldo capturing another Ballon d'Or award. In 2014–15 he netted 48 goals to lead La Liga in scoring. Ronaldo netted his 324th goal as a member of Real in October 2015 to become the club's all-time leading goal scorer. He scored 35 La Liga goals in 2015–16 and helped Real win its record 11th Champions League title, and in December 2016 he won a fourth career Ballon d'Or for his accomplishments. Ronaldo scored 42 goals for Real across all competitions in 2016–17 and led his team to La Liga and Champions League titles that season, which resulted in a fifth career Ballon d'Or award. In 2017–18 he scored 44 goals in 44 games, and Real won a third straight Champions League title.

In July 2018 he reached a four-year contract [worth](#) €112 million (about \$132 million) with the Italian powerhouse [Juventus](#). He finished his Real career with 311 goals in 292 matches. He scored 28 goals in his first season with Juventus—his lowest domestic goal total since his last season with Manchester United—as the powerhouse club won its eighth straight Italian league title. In the 2019–20 season Ronaldo helped the club capture another league title, and Juventus later won the 2020 Supercoppa Italiana and the 2021 Coppa Italia Final. Several months after the latter match, he left Juventus and returned to Manchester United. His second stint with the club proved disappointing, however. Both Ronaldo and Manchester struggled, and he expressed growing dissatisfaction with the club. In November 2022 his contract was [terminated](#) by “mutual agreement.” The following month Ronaldo signed with the Saudi Arabian club Al Nassr.